London Ambulance Service NHS
NHS Trust

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy – Component 5

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Objective

- Have an understanding of common types of cancer
- Have an understanding of radiotherapy and chemotherapy treatment
- Potential side effects following treatment
- Be aware of neutropenic sepsis
- Management considerations

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Cancer

200 different types of cancer

1 in 2 people will get cancer

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Main types

- Carcinomas - Skin or tissues that line organs
- Lymphomas - Cells of the immune system
- Leukaemia - Blood
- Brain Tumours - Central Nervous System
- Sarcomas - Connective or supportive tissues such as bone, cartilage, fat and muscles

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy Treatment

Chemotherapy is used to treat and kill the cancer cells or to stop these cells from spreading further throughout the body.

Can be combined with radiotherapy.

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Side effects

- Feeling tired most of the time.
- Feeling sick or vomiting.
- Hair loss.
- Increased risk of infections due to lower immune system.
- Sore mouth
- Dry or itchy skin.
- Diarrhoea or constipation

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Neutropenic Sepsis

Potentially fatal complication of cancer treatment such as chemotherapy.

Carries a mortality rate as high as 21%

Always suspect this when going to an unwell patient who has had chemotherapy within the last 6 weeks.

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Management

- Follow the LAS sepsis screening and NEWS2 tool
- Inform the receiving hospital as they may need to put patient into isolation.

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Radiotherapy

Use of radiation usually X-rays

50% of people with have radiotherapy at some point during their treatment.

Works by damaging the DNA of the cells but also affects normal cells.

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Side effects

- Tiredness
- Sore, red or darker than normal skin

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Management

- Manage their symptoms
- Talk to their care team
- Convey if needed

© Department of Clinical Education & Standards

Chemotherapy and Radiotherapy - Component 5

Questions?



© Department of Clinical Education & Standards